Mr. Marmalade

By Noah Haidle

Suggested Characters: ***Actress:*** *Lucy* ***Actor:*** *Sookie (Lucy's Mom), Emily (the babysitter), George, Larry, Mr. Marmalade*

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

*A living room in New Jersey. Lucy is playing with Ken and Barbie when Mr. Marmalade appears. He's very well dressed. Suit, briefcase, nice shoes. Lucy hums as she plays with her dolls. (Music is a way for Lucy to cope with being alone most of the time) Suggested song: Pure Imagination from Willy Wonka & the Chocolate Factory – *See link at the end of this selection for video of this song.*

MR. MARMALADE: **(Pg 5)** Good evening.

LUCY: **(Pg 39)** Mr. Marmalade! **(Pg 5)** I thought you weren't coming.

MR. MARMALADE: I carved out some time.

LUCY: Thirty minutes?

MR. MARMALADE: Ten.

LUCY: That's not very many.

MR. MARMALADE: It's the best I could do.

LUCY: We'd better get started.

MR. MARMALADE: What is it today?

LUCY: House.

MR. MARMALADE: *(he opens his briefcase and whips out a tea set)* Whenever you're ready.

(Pantomimes preparations for an elaborate tea party)

LUCY: Would you like a cup of coffee?

MR. MARMALADE: Have we started?

LUCY: Yes.

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MR. MARMALADE: I would love a cup of coffee. *(Lucy begins to prepare a cup when Mr. Marmalade's beeper goes off – Lucy creates this sound effect)* **(Pg 8)** Oh, *shoot*, my beeper.

LUCY: You're not going back to the office tonight, are you, dear?

MR. MARMALADE: Not play beeper. My real beeper. *(Actor moves "off stage" and becomes Sookie, Lucy's mother)*

SOOKIE: **(Pg 6-7)** *(Offstage)* Lucy!?

LUCY: Mom, I'm busy.

SOOKIE: *(Offstage)* Lucy!? What are you doing?

LUCY: Mr. Marmalade just got home from the office, and he has to leave in like five minutes so I'd greatly appreciate it if you left us alone, [MOM]!

MR. MARMALADE: **(Pg 8)** I have to go.

LUCY: You said ten minutes.

MR. MARMALADE: I know I did. I'm sorry. I have to go. Goodbye. *(He disappears)*

LUCY: *(sadly)* Goodbye.

SOOKIE: *(Offstage)* Babysitter'll be here in half an hour. Can you hold down the fort until then?

LUCY: Which one is it?

SOOKIE: *(Offstage)* Emily.

LUCY: Uggghhhh!

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Lynda Barry, an American cartoonist, author and teacher once said: "We don't create a fantasy world to escape reality,*
ACTRESS: *"We create it to be able to stay . . . and to understand what otherwise would be intolerable."*
ACTOR: *Lucy is a young girl with a very active imagination. Her best friend is Mr. Marmalade. Who really doesn't have too much time for her.*
ACTRESS: *Together they create an imaginary world that often echoes too closely the reality that Lucy is struggling to comprehend.*
ACTOR: *As our selection opens, Lucy's mom has left yet again for an evening on the town and Lucy is left in the care of Emily, the babysitter.*
TOGETHER: *Mr. Marmalade by Noah Haidle*

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LUCY: **(Pg 10 – 11)** *(on the phone)* You gotta go? Are you sure? Okay. No. I understand. Ciao.

(Hangs up phone)

EMILY: Who were you talking to? Was it Mr. Marmalade?

LUCY: How do you know Mr. Marmalade?

EMILY: We hang out all the time. We go to the mall and get our nails done.

LUCY: Mr. Marmalade does not get his nails done!!!

EMILY: Chill out. We don't go to the mall. Your Mom told me about him.

LUCY: What'd she say?

EMILY: Says he's a deadbeat.

LUCY: He's very busy. He's a very important man.

EMILY: Don't matter how important he is. He's gotta make time for you. My boyfriend George used to say he was too busy to hang out with me.

LUCY: What'd you do?

EMILY: I stopped hooking up with him.

LUCY: Then did he have more time for you?

EMILY: You better believe he did.

LUCY: . . . Let's play Tea Party.

EMILY: **(Pg 15-16)** *(Rolling her eyes)* When I was your age I liked to play line.

LUCY: How do you play line?

EMILY: You just get in a line and pretend to be waiting for something. I like to wait for the bus.

LUCY: That doesn't sound very fun.

EMILY: Do you want to try it?

LUCY: I guess so.

EMILY: Here, you get behind me. *(They stand in a line)* What are you waiting for?

LUCY: The butcher?

EMILY: No. We're at the bus station. What bus are you waiting for?

LUCY: The number seven.

EMILY: There is not bus number seven, Lucy.

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LUCY: Then I guess it's going to be a long wait.

EMILY: I don't want to hurt your feelings, but you're not very good at Line. *(The doorbell)*

LUCY: Who is that?

EMILY: It's George, my boyfriend.

LUCY: George isn't supposed to come over.

EMILY: We're going to do our math homework. *(She puts on lipstick and fusses with her hair)* How do I look?

LUCY: Easy.

EMILY: Good. *(She adjusts her breasts, trying to make them look bigger. The doorbell rings again)* Coming. I'm coming! *(Off stage . . . Opens door)* . . . You brought Larry?

GEORGE: *(Offstage)* Larry, Lucy. Lucy, Larry. Have fun, kids! *(Sheepishly Larry enters. He's five years old)*

LARRY: I'm Larry.

LUCY: Nice to meet you, Larry. *(She kisses him on the cheek)*

LARRY: What are you doing?

LUCY: It's how people greet each other. . . . **(Pg 19-20)** [so] do you want to play Doctor? *(Larry nods, speechless)* What seems to be the problem?

LARRY: Nothing. I feel fine.

LUCY: No, not what's really the matter. Pretend.

LARRY: *(Pretending to be in great pain as he grabs a body part)* Ohhhhh. I'm having chest pains.

LUCY: That's very serious. You need a heart transplant. Let's get you that new heart! *(The pair pantomime an elaborate heart transplant procedure – kid style based on what they've obviously seen on television shows, complete with sound effects)* How's that new heart?

LARRY: I don't have the chest pains anymore.

LUCY: You've made a complete recovery! **(Pg 16)** *(Larry walks around the room)* Hey!

LARRY: This place is pretty nice. So you live here with your parents and everything?

LUCY: It's just me and my mom. My dad, he divorced my mom when I was two, or something.

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******* Flashback in the world of pretend – a baby cries in the kitchen.*******

In this flashback, Lucy plays her MOM and Mr. Marmalade plays her DAD

MR. MARMALADE: (Pg 41-43) Will you shut that kid up?

LUCY: *(Offstage)* I can't hear you, honey. The baby's crying.

MR. MARMALADE: I know the baby's crying. I can hear the baby crying.

LUCY: *(Offstage)* Just a second! *(She comes in carrying a baby wrapped in a blanket - crying)*

MR. MARMALADE: Put a muzzle on that kid!

LUCY: She'll be back asleep in a minute.

MR. MARMALADE: But then she'll be awake in another minute. Go back in the kitchen! I can't hear myself think.

LUCY: I'm so sorry. *(to baby)* Shhhh. Shhhh. Be quiet. Be quiet.

MR. MARMALADE: Who's idea was it to have a kid anyway?

LUCY: She'll be quiet in a second. Shhhhh. Shhhhh.

MR. MARMALADE: You should have had an abortion.

LUCY: Don't say that?

MR. MARMALADE: Why not? That kid is killing me.

LUCY: It was your idea to have a big family.

MR. MARMALADE: Like hell it was.

LUCY: You said you wanted it all. A house with a white picket fence. Kids running around.

MR. MARMALADE: I never said that.

LUCY: Yes, you did.

MR. MARMALADE: You're putting words in my mouth! *(he hits her in the face, Lucy reacts – long pause)* I can't take this anymore. I'm leaving.

LUCY: You can't leave! I won't bother you. I won't make a sound. I promise. . . . . I won't nag you about your drinking. Do you want another beer? I'll go get you another beer.

MR. MARMALADE: It's too late.

*******Flashback ends*******

LUCY: (Pg 22-24) *(to Larry)* You have to go.

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LARRY: What? Why?

LUCY: Because I said so.

LARRY: Did I do something wrong?

LUCY: No, I can't explain. I'm sorry. You just have to leave. Right now.

LARRY: Okay. I don't understand. But I'll go anyway.

LUCY: I shouldn't have played Doctor with you. I shouldn't have led you on.

LARRY: Yeah. Okay. Maybe I'll see you at school. *(He exits.)*

LUCY: Yeah. See you at school.

*******Scene Change *******

(Alone, Lucy again picks up a doll and begins to hum)

MR. MARMALADE: **(Pg 25-27)** Good evening, [Lucy].

LUCY: *(excited to see him)* [Mr. Marmalade, what are you doing here?] I thought we were having brunch on Sunday?

MR. MARMALADE: Some time freed up tonight. Thought I'd drop by.

LUCY: [Oh . . .] How was work?

MR. MARMALADE: *Freakin'* nightmare. You have no idea.

LUCY: *(taken aback at his obviously drunken demeanor)* Have you been drinking?

MR. MARMALADE: I had a few after work to unwind. You would too if you'd ever worked a day in your life.

LUCY: I wouldn't know.

MR. MARMALADE: No, you wouldn't. *(Mr. Marmalade opens his briefcase. Takes out a [flask of alcohol and drinks] *note in the play this is a vial of cocaine* - substance has been changed here in consideration of high school performers.)*

LUCY: *(Scolding)* Mr. Marmalade!

MR. MARMALADE: What? You want some?

LUCY: *(taken aback)* No. I don't!

MR. MARMALADE: Suit yourself. *(takes another drink)* You sure? This is some good *stuff*. Hey, let's play House. "Hey honey, I'm home!"

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LUCY: *(softly)* No.

MR. MARMALADE: That's when you say, "How was work?" And I say, "It sucked." But somebody's gotta provide for this family. *(Silence . . . Lucy is near tears)* [What?] You don't want to play House with me?

LUCY: Not like this. Not when you're [drunk].

MR. MARMALADE: *(brandishing his flask)* This is like a cup of coffee. I don't even feel it. Hey, Lucy, I work twenty hours a day. *(getting angry and reaching for Lucy)* I want to play House!

LUCY: *(avoiding Mr. Marmalade)* I won't play House with you.

MR. MARMALADE: *(grabbing for her arm again)* Then let's play Doctor. Come here!

LUCY: Get out!

MR. MARMALADE: *(calming down)* Okay, okay. I'll see you on Sunday.

LUCY: No, you won't.

MR. MARMALADE: What?

LUCY: I don't want to see you anymore. *(the following lines overlap as the tension and volume rises)*

MR. MARMALADE: What? What the *hell* you talking about?

LUCY: I don't want to play House with you anymore. Or Doctor.

MR. MARMALADE: *(angry, yelling)* What the *hell* you talking about?

LUCY: *(also yelling to be heard)* I don't want to play with you at all. *(long silence)* You're a bad person. *(growing in intensity with each sentence)* You neglect me. I deserve a lot better than you, [Dad!] *(long silence – Mr. Marmalade exits) (Actor re-enters scene as Larry)*

LARRY: **(Pg 29)** *(Sees that Lucy is upset)* Are you okay? *(Looks offstage)* Who was that guy?

LUCY: He used to be my friend. His name's Mr. Marmalade.

LARRY: That guy was your friend?

LUCY: People change. He used to be a good guy.

LARRY: Well, he's not anymore.

LUCY: Larry? . . . . Do you know how to play House?

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AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2025 National Qualifier
NIETOC
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
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Song: Pure Imagination from Willy Wonka and the Chocolate Factory -
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RZ-uV72pQKI

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